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Environmental Identity: A Conceptual and an Operational Definition

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Identity can be described as a way of organizing information about the self. Just as there are multiple ways of organizing this information, we have multiple identities, varying in salience and importance according to the immediate context and to our past experiences. Each level of identity may suggest its own perspective. When I am focusing on myself as unique I focus on issues that affect me personally and I may emphasize my personal merit and welfare, while when I think of myself as a group member I am aware of issues that affect my group, and the welfare of the group may be of primary concern. Understanding which identities are salient is important for understanding how people react to a particular threat or distribution of rewards.

Because the social aspects of identity are so obvious and so important, psychologists often overlook the impact of nonsocial (or at least non-human) objects in defining identity. Yet there are clearly many people for whom an important aspect of their identity lies in ties to the natural world: connections to specific natural objects such as pets, trees, mountain formations, or particular geographic locations (which has been studied under the rubric of “place identity”). This is not limited to those who are labeled “environmentalists” by virtue of a political position; many who are associated with positions that are considered anti-environmental nevertheless demonstrate, through words or behavior, their love of some aspect of the natural world.

This chapter develops the rationale for talking about an environmental identity. I propose that an environmental identity is one part of the way in which people form their self-concept: a sense of connection to some part of the nonhuman natural environment, based on history, emotional attachment, and/or similarity, that affects the ways in which we

perceive and act toward the world; a belief that the environment is important to us and an important part of who we are. An environmental identity can be similar to another collective identity (such as a national or ethnic identity) in providing us with a sense of connection, of being part of a larger whole, and with a recognition of similarity between ourselves and others. Also like a group identity, an environmental identity can vary in both definition and importance among individuals. I present a scale for assessing individual differences in environmental identity and evidence for the utility of such a scale in predicting reactions to environmental issues. I close by discussing the implications of environmental identity for personal and political behavior.

Self-concept can vary from situation to situation; William James argued that people can be said to have as many social selves as there are groups of people whose opinions matter to them (James, 1950). Why single out environmental identity as particularly worthy of examination? An identity is both a product and a force (see Rosenberg, 1981): an assortment of beliefs about the self and a motivator of particular ways of interacting with the world. In this chapter I argue that the natural environment has the potential to be a distinctively rich source of self-relevant beliefs.

As a motivating force, a strong environmental identity also can have a significant impact by guiding personal, social, and political behavior. (Chapter 2 gives some examples of people whose environmental identity has guided their life choices.) The current importance of, and concern about, environmental behavior thus provides another reason for examining environmental identity.

Environmental Identity as Product

Although the impossibility of experimental research precludes a definite conclusion, we can speculate that environmental identities come from interactions (e.g., with the natural world) and from socially constructed understandings of oneself and others (including nature) (Chawla, 1999). In order to conclude that these experiences have resulted in a significant identity, we should find that they are emotionally significant and that they affect the ways in which people think about themselves.

Emotional Connections to the Natural Environment

People tend to value nature, as evinced by their willingness to expend resources of time or money on nature (paying a premium in order to have natural views out one's window; devoting many hours to one's garden) or to endure discomfort (sleeping on the ground, hiking or driving long distances) in order to interact with it. This is not to deny that some people have lower thresholds for such expenditures or discomfort than others (see, e.g., Bixler & Floyd, 1997), but for most people there is at least some value to experiences with the natural environment that cannot be accounted for by the usual motivators of money, sex, food, and social status. Consider the following statistics for the United States: In 2001, 59 percent of a representative sample of the population thought that protecting the environment was more important than producing energy (CBS News poll, September 4, 2001); 52 percent of a different sample said protecting the environment was more important than encouraging economic growth (ABC News poll, August 1, 2001), and 61 percent of a third sample agreed that "protecting the environment is so important that requirements and standards cannot be too high and continuing environmental improvements must be made regardless of cost" (CBS/*New York Times* poll, March 13, 2001).

Systematic empirical research has shown fairly consistently that people prefer natural to human-influenced settings. They give high ratings to slides or photographs of natural scenery compared with scenes of the built environment (Herzog, Black, Fountain, & Knotts, 1997); among scenes of the built environment, those with some natural component (trees, flowers) are preferred to those without them; even undistinguished natural scenes are preferred to fairly attractive urban scenes or townscapes (R. Kaplan & Kaplan, 1989). Even in guided imagery, natural scenes are preferred over non-natural scenes (Segal, 1999). When people are asked to describe a favorite place, natural settings predominate (Korpela, Hartig, Kaiser, & Fuhrer, 2001; Moore, 1990). Nature doesn't have to be "out there," at a remove from daily living, in order to be valued. In an extensive investigation of "the meaning of things" for individuals, Csikszentmihalyi and Rochberg-Halton (1981) asked members of eighty-two families what things in their home were most special to them. Fifteen percent of the respondents (forty-seven people) mentioned

plants; significantly, plants were described as embodying personal values more often than any other type of object.

Public support for policies that protect the environment tends to be quite high (Ritov & Kahneman, 1997), so much so that even ads for products and businesses that are harmful to the environment are often portrayed as promoting environmental protection, a phenomenon known as “greenwashing” (Bruno, 2001). There are some differences in support that are related to individual background, but they do not cancel out the general tendency. Despite stereotypes to the contrary, an appreciation for the natural environment does not seem to be limited by ethnicity or economic status (see, e.g., Kahn, 1999; Morrissey & Manning, 2000).

One explanation for the attraction of natural settings is the biophilia hypothesis, first proposed by E. O. Wilson (1984) and elaborated since then by Kellert and Wilson (1993). The biophilia hypothesis proposes that humans have inherited a genetic tendency to respond to the natural environment in certain ways, particularly with certain emotional responses. Such a tendency, it is argued, would have been adaptive in a hunter-gatherer type of society, leading us to attend to important environmental dangers, such as tigers and snakes, with a high degree of interest and to prefer to live in settings that would be more conducive to our survival. Like all theories about a genetic basis for human behavior, it is difficult to prove and controversial, although there is some evidence to support it (see Ulrich, 1993). If the hypothesis is valid, then a connection to nature is a fundamental part of who we are.

Without referring to prehistory or genetics, the preference for natural environments may be explained as being due to their psychological and physiological benefits. Kellert (1997) has detailed the many direct and indirect benefits we derive from nature even today, including improved physical fitness, self-confidence, curiosity, and calm. Positive effects of nature have been found on students, the elderly, and hospital patients, as measured by self-report, performance, physiological indices of arousal, and recordings of brain activity. Exposure to a view of a natural environment (e.g., through a window) or access to a nearby natural setting such as a park or garden, has been shown to strengthen cognitive awareness, memory, and general well-being and to decrease depression, boredom, loneliness, anxiety, and stress (Hartig, Mang, & Evans,

1991; Parsons, Tassinary, Ulrich, Hebl, & Grossman-Alexander, 1998; Ulrich, 1984).

R. Kaplan and Kaplan (1989) and S. Kaplan (1995) have discussed the ability of the natural environment to serve as a restorative setting for people. By engaging our attention, taking us away from our mundane activities and settings, and providing a level of stimulation that is neither overly arousing nor boring, the natural environment allows us to replenish our attentional resources. Research by the Kaplans and others (Herzog et al., 1997; Korpela et al., 2001) has shown that people rate natural settings as the best place for achieving these restorative goals.

Environment and Self-Knowledge

To constitute an important aspect of identity, the natural environment must influence the way in which people think about themselves. The natural environment provides the opportunity not only for attentional restoration but also for self-reflection (Herzog et al., 1997). By allowing people the time and space to think about their own values, goals, and priorities, as well as, perhaps, providing relief from the usual concerns of self-presentation, the natural environment can play a vital role in the extent to which we define ourselves to ourselves. One study (Young & Crandall, 1984) even found a slight positive relationship between wilderness use and self-actualization. Self-actualized people (e.g., Maslow, 1970) are described as more accepting of themselves, more sensitive to their own feelings, more independent of their social environment, and as fulfilling their own potential: “They are people who have developed or are developing to the full stature of which they are capable” (Maslow, 1970, p. 150).

The self is often described as including the knower and the known—that is, that which perceives the self and the content of what is perceived (see Ashmore & Jussim, 1997). The natural environment may enable a person to become both a more perceptive knower and a more positively valued known. We understand ourselves better and like ourselves more.

Nature can provide increased understanding of our own abilities and influence in part because it does not change very much in response to a person’s behavior; only our own position in nature changes (Scherl, 1989). In a social environment, other people respond to us in a way that is affected, not only by our own behavior, but also by their perception

of our behavior, our appearance and status, and by other forces that are invisible to us. If someone is rude to me, I cannot always tell what I may have done to elicit such behavior, or if I have done anything at all. This makes it difficult to predict the effect or outcome of my behavioral choices in the future. In a natural environment, it is clear what can be controlled and what cannot. If I am cold, it is because I did not accurately anticipate or appropriately dress for the local weather. The weather changes, but not in response to my behavior. Animals often do respond to us, but their motives (self-protection, hunger) tend to be straightforward and the impetus for their behavior clear. The link between my behavior and its consequences may be clearer in a natural than in a social environment.

In a broader sense, the natural environment informs us about what it means to be human (see chapter 4). We can only gain a thorough sense of our human identity—including, perhaps, an appropriate level of humility in the face of our own limitations—through comparison with nonhuman entities.

The natural environment also may be able to encourage a strong and positive sense of self. Three qualities seem to be desired parts of everyone's identity: autonomy, or self-direction; relatedness, or connection; and competence (Ryan & Deci, 2000). Perceived autonomy can be enhanced in a natural environment because there are fewer commands or requests from others that limit behavioral choices. Although the physical environment provides some constraints on behavior, the limits are less explicit than in a social setting where one is ruled by laws, signs, and the expectations of others. Fredrickson and Anderson (1999) obtained detailed information about the experiences of women on trips in the wilderness. On the basis of interviews and journals, Fredrickson and Anderson state "For many of these women what made their wilderness experience especially meaningful was the fact that there was virtually no reason to be anyone but themselves" (1999, p. 30).

Relatedness comes from the opportunity to feel like a part of a functioning system. Aron and McLaughlin-Volpe (2001) have argued that "self-expansion" is a fundamental human motivation, which can be achieved through redefining the self in a way that includes others. Many seem to reach this state through experiences with the natural environment. For some people it is experienced as a spiritual dimension, a connection with Mother Earth, or a unity with Gaia; for others, it is simply

a way of fitting oneself into the larger picture, as part of an environment, a world, a functioning ecosystem. This redefinition of self is one of the primary tenets of deep ecology (Naess, 1989).

Competence comes from the feeling of self-sufficiency: getting around under our own steam; perhaps showing survival skills through living off the land, climbing a steep mountain, or staring down one's fear of the dark. The women interviewed by Fredrickson and Anderson (1999) talked about the sense of accomplishment they experienced, and of getting to know their own physical capabilities. R. Kaplan and Kaplan (1989) have shown that people's preference of natural to human-influenced environments is related to their perceived competence in a natural environment. The sense of competence can also be a significant part of experiences with nature in an urban setting (see chapter 10). It is interesting that De Young (2000) has also emphasized the importance of the desire for competence in motivating environmentally sustainable behavior.

The natural environment thus seems to provide a particularly good source of self-definition, based on an identity formed through interaction with the natural world and on self-knowledge obtained in an environmental context.

Environmental Identity as Force

The validity and utility of the construct of environmental identity depend on some evidence that it affects our thinking or behavior, and does so better than other determinants, such as attitudes. The idea of environmental identity enables us to see the relevance of the self to interactions over environmental issues. Environmental attitudes are espoused not, in many cases, because of a belief that they will be listened to, but in order to define oneself by expressing one's fundamental values and ethical standards (L. L. Thompson & Gonzales, 1997). Donations to environmental organizations are not made to increase perceived personal utility but to obtain moral satisfaction (Ritov & Kahneman, 1997). Environmental behaviors are engaged in, or not, in part because of the way in which these behaviors convey information about the self and group affiliations.

This raises the issue of individual differences in the strength and/or definition of an environmental identity. Some people receive validation and pleasure from reducing resource use; as DeYoung (2000) has noted,

environmentally sustainable behavior becomes self-interested when an individual cares about the natural environment and values its well-being. Clearly, however, there are others who do not find environmental behaviors intrinsically rewarding.

Schultz (2000) has argued that environmental concerns are a function of the extent to which “people include nature in their cognitive representation of self” (p. 403). Previous research (Davis, Conklin, Smith, & Luce, 1996) has shown that a perspective taking manipulation increases the perceived interconnectedness between the self and others. Schultz found support for his hypothesis when he encouraged college students to adopt the perspective of an animal that was shown as being harmed by environmental degradation (oil spills, litter, etc.), thus presumably increasing the perceived relatedness between the student and the animal. This manipulation led to an increase in the students’ rated concerns for environmental entities, although merely viewing the picture without taking the animals’ perspective did not have that effect. In related work, Opatow (e.g., 1994; Opatow & Weiss, 2000) has discussed how concern for environmental entities is based on including those entities within our moral community.

The Environmental Identity Scale

In order to examine whether individual differences in environmental identity can predict behavior, I have constructed a scale to assess the extent to which the natural environment plays an important part in a person’s self-definition—what I have called an Environmental Identity (EID) Scale (see the appendix). The structure of the scale was based in part on discussions of the factors that determine a collective social identity, such as an ethnic identity (cf. Luhtanen & Crocker, 1992; Sellers, Smith, Shelton, Rowley, & Chavous, 1998; Tajfel, 1981). Such factors include the salience of the identity, the identification of oneself as a group member, agreement with an ideology associated with the group, and the positive emotions associated with the collective.

With regard to the natural world, I operationalized salience by asking about the extent and importance of an individual’s interactions with nature (e.g., “I spend a lot of time in natural settings”). Self-identification was assessed through the way in which nature contributes to the collectives with which one identifies (“I think of myself as a part

of nature, not separate from it”). Ideology was measured by support for environmental education and a sustainable lifestyle. (“Behaving responsibly toward the Earth—living a sustainable lifestyle—is part of my moral code.”) Positive emotions were measured by asking about the enjoyment obtained in nature, through satisfaction and aesthetic appreciation (“I would rather live in a small room or house with a nice view than a bigger room or house with a view of other buildings”). On the assumption that environmental identity results from experiences with nature, the scale also includes an autobiographical component, based on memories of interacting with nature (“I spent a lot of my childhood playing outside”).

It is important to acknowledge that an environmental identity is also at least in part a social identity (see chapter 14). An understanding of oneself in a natural environment cannot be fully separated from the social meanings given to nature and to environmental issues, which will vary according to culture, world view, and religion. The scale I have created is very much mediated by North American understandings of the ways in which we value and interact with nature, and research with the EID scale has thus far been limited to North American college students. I would expect some, but not all, of the constructs to vary across cultures.

In several studies that have been conducted using the EID scale, it has proven to have good internal reliability. In three studies, Cronbach’s alpha has been 0.90 or above for the twenty-four-item scale. Factor analyses suggest that a single factor accounts for most of the variance, although this may change when the test is administered to a more diverse sample. Although social desirability pressures might be expected to lead to high scores, the scale is relatively free from floor or ceiling effects; out of a possible range of 24–196, it had an actual range of 62–191 and a mean of 128.4 in one study and 63–180 and a mean of 125.4 in another. Women tend to score slightly higher than men, but the differences are usually not significant.

Study 1: The Validity of the EID Scale

To evaluate the convergent, discriminant, and predictive validity of the EID scale, I had seventy-three students complete a series of related measures assessing environmental attitudes, general values and ideology, and behavior.

Identity Compared with Attitudes and Values The first measure was the Environmental Attitudes Scale (S. Thompson & Barton, 1994). This measures three components of environmental attitudes: ecocentrism, or a valuing of nature for its own sake; anthropocentrism, or a valuing of nature for its utility to humans; and apathy toward the environment and environmental issues.

The students also completed a twenty-four-item value survey, similar to that described by Schwartz (1992), in which they rated twenty-four values according to the importance of the value in their own lives. Three values were included to tap each of eight dimensions identified by Schwartz: self-enhancement, hedonism, stimulation, universalism, self-determination, benevolence, tradition, and conformity. The “universalism” items were specifically selected to represent environmental values (“a world of beauty,” “protecting the environment,” and “unity with nature”), while other items that Schwartz classified as universalist were considered to fall in the “benevolence” category (equality, social justice). A factor analysis confirmed that eight essentially uncorrelated factors were represented, and that the environmental items loaded primarily on a different factor than did the benevolence items.

A third instrument was designed to measure individualism and collectivism, and was abbreviated from one suggested by Triandis (1995). This was designed to assess the extent to which participants think of themselves primarily as independent individuals or as interdependent members of a larger community. Triandis summarizes the differences between an individualistic world view and a collectivist world view as follows: Collectivists think of the self as interdependent, believe that personal and communal goals are aligned, focus on their interpersonal norms and obligations, and emphasize relationships. Individualists think of the self as independent of others, believe that personal and communal goals are not the same, focus on their personal rights and attitudes, and evaluate relationships in terms of personal utility. Triandis also makes a distinction between a vertical and a horizontal perspective, either of which can accompany individualism or collectivism. A vertical perspective emphasizes difference and hierarchy, while a horizontal perspective emphasizes similarity. In the present study, only horizontal collectivism and vertical individualism emerged as coherent subscales.

I have argued elsewhere (e.g., Clayton, 1996, 1998) that an environmental perspective is more compatible with collectivism than with individualism. Environmentalists by definition tend to focus on the larger community—the species or the ecosystem. Environmental arguments stress interdependence and often refer to duties and obligations. The position opposed to the environmental argument, in contrast, focuses on individual entitlements (e.g., property rights) and often relies on market pricing to resolve environmental conflicts—a classic individualist approach (Opatow & Clayton, 1998).

I expected the EID scores to correlate positively with ecocentrism and negatively with apathy, to correlate with a high rating for the universalism factor from the value survey, and to correlate positively with horizontal collectivism and negatively with vertical individualism. In all cases, the EID score showed a pattern of correlations consistent with the hypotheses. It was significantly correlated with ecocentrism (0.79), apathy (−0.69), the universal values factor (0.66) but no other values, horizontal collectivism (0.37), and vertical individualism (−0.29).

Identity and Behavior The last and probably most important measure to show the validity of the EID scale was a measure of behavior. In the same study, I devised a twenty-one-item self-report of behavior, which asked students to indicate on a five-point scale the extent to which they engaged in a range of environmentally sustainable actions, from “turn lights off when leaving a room” (this item had the highest mean, at 4.18), to “donate money to environmental organizations” (this had the lowest mean, at 1.58). The overall average mean was 2.82, suggesting that students were not overly inflating their estimates of reported actions and that social desirability pressures were not creating a ceiling effect. The overall internal reliability for this scale was 0.85. The EID scores showed a significant correlation with environmental behaviors, $r = 0.64$.

It could be argued that the EID measure is essentially replicating one of the other measures, most likely environmental attitudes, but possibly also values or collectivist ideology. To test this possibility, I calculated two sets of partial correlations: the relationship between the EID score and behavior while holding constant the other predictor variable (attitudes, values, or ideology), and the relationship between the other predictor variable and behavior while holding the EID score constant. In all cases,

the correlation between the EID score and behavior remained significant even with the other variable held constant, but the correlation between the other variable and behavior became insignificant when the EID score was held constant. This shows that the relationship between the EID score and behavior is due primarily to a unique variance not shared with the other predictors, but that the relationship between the other predictors and behavior is due to the variance shared with the EID score.

Study 2: Identity and Environmental Conflict

The EID scale seemed to have personal relevance as a predictor of individual behavior. I also wanted to determine whether it might predict a more social outcome by affecting position in an environmental conflict. Eighty college students were presented with written descriptions of two environmental conflicts, which were adapted from newspaper accounts of real environmental issues. The students were presented with two possible resolutions of the conflict (one that would protect the environment and one that would harm the environment) and asked to decide which they preferred. They also rated the perceived importance of their decision, the difficulty of making the decision, and their certainty that they had made the right decision. Finally, they completed the EID scale.

Clearly, college students reading about an issue may make different decisions than people in an actual conflict situation; these choices should not be interpreted as predicting the corresponding behavior. However, many environmental attitudes are formed on the basis of exposure to just such incomplete information, and college students have as much exposure to environmental issues as most other citizens. The choices could represent political choices, such as votes for or against a policy.

The EID score was significantly related to individuals' decisions, so that a higher score was associated with the proenvironmental choice ($r = 0.27, 0.38$ for the two conflicts); to how important they thought the decision was ($r = 0.45, 0.38$); to how certain they felt that their decision was right ($r = 0.35, 0.20$); and interestingly, to a tendency to find the decision less difficult (although this did not quite reach standard significance levels; $r = -0.21, -0.20$). Previous research has shown that we process information that is self-relevant more quickly than information that is not, which may explain the correlation with difficulty (Markus, 1977); more research is needed to substantiate this hypothesis.

Study 3: Identity and Justice

A third study was conducted to examine whether the EID score related not just to the decision a person makes but also to the criteria for a good decision. It could be argued that a decision one makes about a public conflict is essentially a political decision, and could be indicative of a number of different motivations, including the sense that a particular position is more “politically correct” or socially desirable. (In the second study, 67 of 80 made a proenvironmental decision in one scenario and 53 of 80 chose the proenvironmental position in the other scenario.) The principles upon which one relies to make a good decision, however, should be tied to deeper personal beliefs.

In this study, 115 students were presented with three different environmental conflict scenarios: one describing a conflict between city governments and low-income city residents over abandoned lots that were developed into community gardens, one about the conflict between making national parks accessible to the public and leaving them undeveloped, and one concerning government regulation of private land development. Following each scenario, the students were asked not to resolve the conflict, but to indicate how much weight they would give to each of thirteen different factors in resolving the conflict. These factors were chosen to represent different principles of justice that could be considered in trying to arrive at a fair decision, including equality, equity, fair process, rights, and responsibilities as applied to different moral entities. The order of presentation was randomized. Following these ratings, students filled out the EID form.

The EID score was generally unrelated to nine of the thirteen principles, but was consistently (across scenario) positively related to the rated importance of two factors: “responsibility to other species,” and “the rights of the environment,” (multivariate $F [3, 108] = 7.64, p < .001$; and $7.98, p < .001$, respectively; univariate F 's for each scenario were also significant). A third principle, “responsibility to future generations,” was related to the EID score in each scenario at levels that approached significance ($p < .10$). In other words, people high in environmental identity accord more weight than people low in environmental identity to those principles that endow environmental entities with moral standing. The EID score was also related to an increased rating for a fourth principle, “managing natural resources for the public good,” in the

abandoned lots and private lands scenarios (and achieved overall significance: multivariate $F [3, 107] = 3.79, p < .05$), but was unrelated to this principle in the national parks scenario, probably because the interests of the public and the interests of the natural environment were potentially conflicting in that case.

In sum, environmental identity seems to serve as a part of individuals' self-definition and, as such, as a predictor of individual behavior. It also has significance as a determinant of how individuals position themselves with regard to social situations, such as environmental policies or conflicts over environmental resources. Not just position, but also valued principles and certainty about one's position are related to environmental identity.

The Uses and Limits of Identity in Understanding Political and Personal Behavior

The Environmental Identity Scale is presented as a useful tool for measuring individual differences in the sense of the self in relation to the natural environment in order to draw conclusions about other variables associated with those differences. As such, it appears to have good psychometric properties. The research presented here has supported the idea that environmental identity is a meaningful and measurable construct, with consequences for attitudes and behavior, and that by thinking about environmental identity we learn something beyond what we learn by talking about attitudes and values. The EID scale is not intended to be a definitive operationalization of environmental identity. As is clear from this book as a whole, there are myriad ways of thinking and talking about environmental identity, most of which are not mutually exclusive.

The EID scale is also presented in the hopes of furthering consideration and stimulating research on environmental identity as a useful psychological construct. What does it mean to think about individuals as having varying levels of an environmental identity? What questions can usefully be empirically addressed? The EID scale, administered before and after an environmental intervention, might serve as a useful measure of the extent to which real-world policies have affected the way in which individuals think about their relationship to the environment.

Identities originate within a social context that gives meaning to our encounters with nature. Identities also have social significance, promoting certain group affiliations and activities and discouraging others. The focus of this chapter is primarily on individual identity as a product of individual experiences; the social implications of identity, however, are clear. In many ways, the natural environment has become a political issue, with highly controversial policies constantly on the public agenda. Environmental identity can function to affiliate people with well-defined social groups. It can become a political identity in a way that is divisive rather than integrative. In trying to understand people's reactions to environmental issues, we need to understand that positions are taken and behaviors engaged in, not just because of an assessment of costs and benefits, but partly because of the associations between these positions and behaviors and group affiliations. There are bumper stickers that contain slogans like "pave the rainforest" and "nuke the baby seals." It seems unlikely that the drivers whose cars are decorated by these stickers really have anything against the rainforest or baby seals; rather, they are hostile toward the people ("environmentalists") whom they associate with support for the rainforest and for baby seals. Environmental politics has become identity politics, and conflicts can escalate as people link their identity to particular positions (see chapter 12). It would be instructive to administer the EID scale to groups on opposite sides of an environmental conflict and see if changes occur as positions harden and the groups polarize.

Compared with a group identity, an environmental identity has some significant differences. It has the advantage of having no fixed geographic boundaries; this means that it is difficult to tie it to another group classification, such as a national identity. The protean membership of groups defined from an environmental identity perspective should make it harder for intergroup conflicts to become firm, as has been discovered in alliances between hunters and vegetarians to protect wildlife habitat, or between labor and environmental groups to reduce exposure to hazardous waste. Affiliations with the natural environment may thus be used to overcome intergroup hostility, as with the cross-national "peace parks" that are designed to encourage neighboring countries to work together to protect an ecosystem that does not stop at national boundaries (Weed, 1994). Similarly, Oskamp (2000) suggests that

environmental sustainability can be used as a superordinate goal toward which all nations and peoples can work, overcoming their internal hostilities. Perhaps if the EID scale were used with opposing groups, we might discover that despite group differences on some items, there were similarities on others. These could serve as a foundation to encourage the recognition of intergroup similarities.

Moving beyond the use of the scale, we can use the idea of an environmental identity to motivate environmental behavior. An environmental identity locates us within a collective that is truly an interdependent system. If we recognize the significance and value of other members of the system, including nonhuman entities, that is one step toward acknowledging the (limited) rights of those entities, the way in which they are affected by our own actions, and the obligations that we owe them (Clayton, 1996). Cause and effect, the role that people play in maintaining the health of the system, are more easily seen than in a social group. An environmental identity can be recognized, nurtured, and used to encourage conservation behavior when the natural objects being protected are tied to the self, thus allowing the motivation to be internal rather than external. This is why people “buy” an acre of the rain forest for their very own (and receive a certificate to that effect), or “adopt” a particular whale, seal, or stretch of highway. When the health and success of a natural object are made more self-relevant, they are worth more to the individual.

This recognition of interdependence and obligation, however, also makes it hard to acknowledge an environmental identity. Acknowledging an environmental identity entails a shift in worldview that may be difficult (see, e.g., Dunlap & Van Liere, 1978; Dunlap, Van Liere, Mertig, & Jones, 2000). It removes us from the center; the value of things is not based only on their value to us. It limits our control; we have to love what we get rather than create what we want. It forces us to really recognize and value difference rather than ignoring it. A response can be to deny environmental identity or to anthropomorphize (see chapter 5)—to pretend animals and even trees are just like us and thus can thrive in a human-dominated world.

The fact that we have different sources of identity means that an environmental identity is not enough to ensure environmental responsibility (see chapter 6). An environmental identity has to be salient, and it has

to motivate us to gain the knowledge we need to understand our impact on the environment. It is easy to stop with our own local or personal bit of nature: to support a neighborhood park but not the preservation of national parks; to support zoos but not protect the habitat of animals we will never see or do not like; to plant a garden but condone the destruction of rainforests. We are all challenged to walk the line between denying connection and denying difference: learning to accept responsibility without ownership. Environmental identity as assessed by the EID scale is perhaps less about differences in emotional connection to nature and more about differences in the significance, prominence, and scope of that connection. To give a twist to a phrase from the women's movement, an environmental identity is what we need in order to recognize that the personal is political and vice versa: that our immediate local actions can have global consequences, and that remote environmental threats are personally significant.

When I go to my local garden center, especially on a sunny day in spring, there are large numbers of people spending hard-earned money on flowers, vegetables, shrubs, trees, and grass seed. Their motives, although diverse, are almost certainly self-relevant. They enjoy the feeling of competence derived from digging in the dirt and getting things to grow; or they may be concerned with self-presentation, wanting their garden to be admired by the neighborhood. Their behavior is not necessarily proenvironmental; on the contrary, they may be harming the local environment by applying pesticides, replacing native with non-native species, and breaking up the habitat of area wildlife. Rather than feeling pessimistic about their behavior, though, I am encouraged by the underlying value it reflects. The connection to nature is there.

Appendix: Items on the Environmental Identity Scale

- 1. I spend a lot of time in natural settings (woods, mountains, desert, lakes, ocean).
- 2. Engaging in environmental behaviors is important to me.
- 3. I think of myself as a part of nature, not separate from it.
- 4. If I had enough time or money, I would certainly devote some of it to working for environmental causes.
- 5. When I am upset or stressed, I can feel better by spending some time outdoors “communing with nature.”

- 6. Living near wildlife is important to me; I would not want to live in a city all the time.
- 7. I have a lot in common with environmentalists as a group.
- 8. I believe that some of today's social problems could be cured by returning to a more rural life-style in which people live in harmony with the land.
- 9. I feel that I have a lot in common with other species.
- 10. I like to garden.
- 11. Being a part of the ecosystem is an important part of who I am.
- 12. I feel that I have roots to a particular geographic location that had a significant impact on my development.
- 13. Behaving responsibly toward the Earth—living a sustainable life-style—is part of my moral code.
- 14. Learning about the natural world should be an important part of every child's upbringing.
- 15. In general, being part of the natural world is an important part of my self-image.
- 16. I would rather live in a small room or house with a nice view than a bigger room or house with a view of other buildings.
- 17. I really enjoy camping and hiking outdoors.
- 18. Sometimes I feel like parts of nature—certain trees, or storms, or mountains—have a personality of their own.
- 19. I would feel that an important part of my life was missing if I was not able to get out and enjoy nature from time to time.
- 20. I take pride in the fact that I could survive outdoors on my own for a few days.
- 21. I have never seen a work of art that is as beautiful as a work of nature, like a sunset or a mountain range.
- 22. My own interests usually seem to coincide with the position advocated by environmentalists.
- 23. I feel that I receive spiritual sustenance from experiences with nature.
- 24. I keep mementos from the outdoors in my room, such as shells or rocks or feathers.

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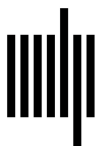
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